

Odd-Jobs Marketplace for Sri Lanka — Product & Launch Strategy

Working name: TBD (suggestions at the end) **Author:** Pamux **Status:** Pre-build strategy document, v1 **Audience:** Solo founder / engineering-led launch

1. The core idea, restated cleanly

A two-sided hyperlocal marketplace where:

- **Posters** publish a one-off task with a fixed budget, location, and time window. Tasks can be odd or unconventional (drop off a car at a garage, queue at a government office, pick up groceries for a sick parent, set up a TV, water plants while away, hand-deliver a document).
- **Doers** are verified individuals nearby who get notified, accept the task, complete it, and get paid through the platform.

The platform owns trust, payments, communication, and dispute resolution. It does not employ doers — they are independent.

This is the same structural pattern as **TaskRabbit (US/UK)**, **Airtasker (Australia/UK)**, and **Urban Company / UrbanClap (India/UAE)**, adapted to Sri Lankan reality.

2. Why this is a real opportunity in Sri Lanka

A few things make Sri Lanka interesting *right now* for this category:

1. **PickMe owns rides + food delivery + parcel courier**, but does *not* own general odd-jobs. PickMe Flash is point-A-to-point-B parcel delivery; it does not handle “spend 3 hours at the garage with my car” or “queue at the bank for me.” There is a real gap.
2. **High smartphone + mobile-money penetration** post-2020. eZ Cash, mCash, FriMi, Genie, and LankaQR are widely accepted; PayHere aggregates them all behind one API.
3. **Underemployment of capable young adults** — three-wheeler drivers, students, between-jobs workers — who would happily take a Rs. 2,000 / 3-hour task if it found them.
4. **Trust deficit in informal labor markets.** Today people find a “guy” through a friend of a friend. There’s no rating, no escrow, no recourse. That’s exactly what a marketplace solves.
5. **Cultural fit:** Sri Lankan urban households (especially Colombo, Kandy, Galle, Negombo) already outsource small jobs informally. You’re formalizing an existing behavior, not inventing one.

The risk side of this picture: PickMe could add this as a feature tomorrow. Your moat has to be either (a) speed to dominate the niche before they notice, (b) a deeper trust/verification layer than they'd bother building, or (c) being demonstrably better at non-delivery tasks (which require longer engagement, more judgment, and richer profiles than ride-hail).

3. What competitors got right and wrong (lessons to copy / avoid)

TaskRabbit (US/UK, acquired by IKEA 2017)

- **Right:** Background checks on doers, escrow payments, in-app chat, two-sided ratings, “Happiness Pledge” insurance up to \$10,000. Took ~30% commission and survived.
- **Wrong:** Stayed too horizontal — never dominated a single vertical. Quality varied because tasks like “cleaning” are subjective. Slow to launch in new markets.
- **Lesson for you:** Pick 5–8 launch categories deliberately. Don't say “anything goes” on day one — you can't moderate it.

Airtasker (Australia, expanded to UK)

- **Right:** Bidding model — doers compete with quotes, posters pick. Works well for non-standard tasks where price isn't obvious.
- **Wrong:** Race-to-the-bottom on bids hurt doer earnings. Heavy moderation cost.
- **Lesson:** Offer **both** “fixed price” (poster sets it, first-accept wins) and “open to bids” (for unusual tasks). Default to fixed-price for simplicity.

Urban Company (India, UAE, Singapore)

- **Right:** Verticalized into beauty + repairs + cleaning. Trained their providers. Standardized pricing. ~20% commission. Big enough to negotiate insurance.
- **Wrong:** Heavy-handed with workers (compulsory product purchases, account blockings) — generated worker backlash and bad press.
- **Lesson:** Treat doers as customers, not labor units. Their churn kills you faster than poster churn.

PickMe (Sri Lanka, your home market)

- **Right:** Trilingual (Sinhala/Tamil/English), supports cash + cashless, real-time tracking, drivers can withdraw earnings instantly.
- **Wrong:** Has had territorial conflicts where non-platform tuk-tuk drivers harass platform drivers, especially in tourist areas like Galle. App UX gets criticized as buggy.

- **Lesson:** Trilingual from day one is non-negotiable. Cash settlement option is non-negotiable. And **think about the doer's physical safety** — especially female doers and doers entering strangers' homes.

4. Enhancements to your original idea

Your core spec is sound. Here's what to add to make it production-grade:

4.1 Verification & trust (the most important layer)

Three tiers of doer verification:

Tier	Requirements	Allowed tasks
Basic (Bronze)	Phone OTP, NIC photo + selfie liveness check, address proof	Outdoor errands, queueing, deliveries under Rs. 5,000 value
Verified (Silver)	Bronze + police clearance certificate (Grama Niladhari letter as interim), 2 reference contacts called by your team	Tasks involving entering a home, handling cash >Rs. 5,000
Trusted (Gold)	Silver + valid driving license (for vehicle tasks), specific skill proof (electrician/plumber cert), 20+ completed jobs with 4.5+ rating	Driving someone else's vehicle, handling expensive items, overnight tasks

Posters can filter by tier. High-risk tasks (your car-to-garage example) require Gold doers.

4.2 Escrow payments — the single biggest trust unlock

When a poster posts a task, the budget is **debited and held by the platform**. The doer sees “funds secured” before accepting. After completion, the poster confirms; funds release to the doer's wallet. If the poster doesn't confirm within 24 hours, auto-release. Disputes pause the release.

This eliminates the #1 fear on both sides: “will I get paid / will they actually do it.” It's also why this is a marketplace and not just a classifieds board.

4.3 Pricing model

Offer two posting modes: - **Fixed price (default)**: Poster names price. First qualified doer to accept gets it. Fast. - **Open to bids**: For unusual or scope-unclear tasks. Doers send price + ETA + short note. Poster picks. Slower but better for non-standard work.

Add a **suggested price hint** (“Tasks like this in Colombo usually pay Rs. 1,800–2,500”) based on completed-task data. This reduces under-pricing, which is the most common reason marketplaces fail to attract doers.

4.4 Two-sided ratings with weighted display

Both poster and doer rate each other after completion. Rating is a simple 1–5 + optional 1-line comment. **Don’t** show ratings as a bare average — show them as **“4.8 across 47 jobs, 96% on-time”** because the numerator/denominator matters more than the score in low-volume markets.

Hide individual reviewer identities; show only first name + first letter of last name.

4.5 In-app chat, not phone exposure

Doer and poster communicate through in-app chat with masked phone numbers (route through a virtual number — services like Hutch/Dialog can provision these, or use Twilio at higher cost). This protects both parties and gives you a record for disputes.

After completion, contact info expires. Prevents off-platform repeat business that bypasses your commission (the #1 marketplace leakage problem).

4.6 Categories at launch (deliberately narrow)

Don’t launch with “anything.” Launch with these because they’re high-frequency, easy to scope, and demonstrate the value prop:

1. **Errands & queueing** (bank/utility/government queues, document submission)
2. **Vehicle services** (drop car at garage, take bike for service, fuel queue if/when shortages return)
3. **Pickup & drop** (forgot a laptop at office, deliver gift to relative — non-courier scope)
4. **Home help** (one-off cleaning, garden cleanup, moving small furniture)
5. **Tech setup** (TV mounting, Wi-Fi setup, smart device install)
6. **Elderly assistance** (accompany to clinic, pay bills in person, grocery run)
7. **Event help** (extra hands at parties, setup, pickup)

Add categories quarterly based on what people try to post in “Other.”

4.7 Safety features

- **Live location share** during active tasks (both sides see each other's live location, like a ride-hail).
- **SOS button** that pings your support team + a designated emergency contact.
- **Photo proof of completion** required before payment release for physical tasks ("photo of car safely parked at home").
- **Female-doer filter** for posters who want a woman doer (cleaning, elderly female care). Female doers can also opt to only accept tasks from female posters or family households.

4.8 Dispute resolution

Build a simple ticket system from day one. You will personally handle disputes for the first 6 months. Patterns from those 200 tickets become your automated rules later.

Reserve **5% of every transaction into a "Trust Fund"** — used to compensate verified losses (damaged property, doer no-show with cash advance, etc.) up to a cap (e.g., Rs. 25,000 per incident at launch). This is the equivalent of TaskRabbit's "Happiness Pledge" and it pays for itself in conversion.

5. Revenue model

Three streams, in order of importance:

1. **Service fee on each completed task** — take **15% from the doer + 5% from the poster** (so the total platform take is ~20% of GMV). Show both fees transparently. This is in line with TaskRabbit (~30%, but they had pricing power) and Urban Company (~20%). Going lower than 15% at launch is fine to seed liquidity, but build the infrastructure assuming 20%.
2. **Doer verification fees** — Rs. 500 one-time for Silver verification, Rs. 1,500 for Gold. Pays for the manual KYC work.
3. **Featured/priority listing for posters** — small premium (Rs. 100–200) to push a task to the top of doers' feeds for urgent jobs.

Avoid subscription revenue at launch — it complicates onboarding when you need frictionless signup.

Cash tasks: Some tasks will inevitably be paid in cash off-platform (especially in suburban/rural markets). Don't fight this in v1 — let posters mark "cash on completion" but charge a flat **Rs. 99 platform fee** at posting time to keep you in the loop. Migrate them to escrow over time as trust builds.

6. Payments — Sri Lanka-specific stack

Use **PayHere** as your primary aggregator. It's Central Bank-approved, gives you Visa, Mastercard, Amex, eZ Cash, mCash, FriMi, Genie, LankaQR, and bank transfers behind **one integration**. Their fees are roughly **3.4% + Rs. 50** per local card transaction, which you bake into your service fee.

For doer payouts, you have two paths:

- **Bank transfer** (CEFTS/SLIPS via your business bank — Sampath, Commercial, NTB all support this). Settles next business day. Cheapest.
- **Mobile wallet payout** (eZ Cash, FriMi). Faster, doer-friendly, slightly higher fees.

Offer both. Default to whichever the doer registered with.

Hold periods: Hold doer payouts for 24 hours after task completion, releasing automatically if no dispute is filed. This protects you against chargebacks and lets you recover funds before they leave the platform.

7. Suggested tech stack (for a solo engineering-led build)

Optimize for **speed to MVP**, **low ops burden**, and **easy hiring later**.

- **Mobile apps:** React Native (Expo) — one codebase for iOS and Android. You're already a web developer, so React + JSX is leverage. Native modules for camera/location only when needed.
- **Backend:** Node.js + Fastify (or NestJS if you want structure) on a single VPS to start. You don't need microservices — PickMe runs 100+, but PickMe is a 10-year-old company with 100k+ drivers. You're not them yet.
- **Database:** PostgreSQL with PostGIS extension (you'll need geospatial queries for "tasks near me"). Add Redis for sessions, presence, and the doer-notification queue.
- **Realtime:** Start with Socket.IO for chat + live location. Migrate to a managed service (Pusher, Ably) only if you outgrow it.
- **Push notifications:** Firebase Cloud Messaging (free, works on both platforms).
- **Maps:** Google Maps SDK. Sri Lanka has decent coverage. Budget for the API costs — they bite at scale.
- **Payments:** PayHere SDK + their REST API for refunds/payouts.
- **KYC/liveness:** Start manual (you review NIC photo + selfie). Move to Onfido or Veriff at ~10k users.
- **Hosting:** A single AWS Lightsail / DigitalOcean droplet (\$20/month) is enough for the first 1,000 users. Don't over-engineer infra in v0.
- **Monitoring:** Sentry (errors) + Plausible (analytics, GDPR-friendly) + UptimeRobot (free).

- **Admin panel:** Build a simple internal Next.js dashboard for KYC review, dispute handling, and metrics. Don't waste time on Retool unless you need to delegate.

Estimated infra cost at launch: \$50–100/month. Scales linearly with usage.

8. MVP scope — what to ship in v1 (target 10–12 weeks)

Cut everything that isn't on this list. You can always add later.

Must-have for launch

- Phone OTP signup, separate poster and doer flows
- Doer NIC + selfie KYC (manually reviewed by you)
- Post a task (title, description, photos, category, location pin, budget, time window)
- Browse nearby tasks (doer side) with map + list view
- Accept task, in-app chat, mark complete with photo proof
- PayHere escrow integration (hold + release)
- Two-sided 1–5 rating
- Basic admin panel for you to review KYC, refund, ban
- Trilingual UI (Sinhala, Tamil, English) — i18n from day one, even if Tamil/Sinhala translations are AI-assisted at launch and refined later
- Push notifications for new tasks (doers) and accepted/messaged (posters)

Skip in v1, build in v2

- Bidding mode (do fixed-price only at first)
- Gold tier verification (only Bronze + Silver at launch)
- Trust Fund payouts (manual case-by-case for the first 6 months)
- Female-doer filter and SOS button (add by month 4 — important but not week-1 critical)
- Featured listings, subscriptions
- Web app for posters (mobile-first; web in v3)

A realistic solo-build timeline: **10–14 weeks** to a launchable MVP if you're working evenings/weekends, **6–8 weeks** full-time. Don't rush KYC and payments — those bugs lose you the company.

9. Go-to-market — how to get the first 1,000 tasks completed

The chicken-and-egg problem will eat you alive if you launch broadly. Do this instead:

Phase 1: Single neighborhood pilot (months 1–2 post-launch)

Pick **one** Colombo suburb you know well — Maharagama, Nugegoda, Rajagiriya, Mount Lavinia — and saturate it. Recruit 30–50 doers personally (Facebook groups, university notice boards, three-wheeler stands). Onboard them in person. Run a closed-beta of 200 posters via your network and theirs. Goal: 100 completed tasks, 4.5+ avg rating.

Phase 2: Colombo expansion (months 3–6)

Open to all of Colombo District. Use the testimonials and case studies from Phase 1. Spend modestly on Facebook/Instagram ads targeting 25–45 year olds in Colombo. Doer-side: partner with one or two universities for student doers (good for queueing/errand tasks).

Phase 3: Other cities (months 7–12)

Kandy, Galle, Negombo, Kurunegala. Each new city repeats the pilot pattern — never launch a city without 30+ pre-recruited doers waiting on day one. Empty marketplaces die.

Acquisition tactics that work in Sri Lanka specifically

- **Facebook groups** (huge in Sri Lanka — apartment community groups, neighborhood groups). Ask permission first; don't spam.
- **Three-wheeler driver networks** — they're already mobile, already comfortable with apps from PickMe, and already trusted in their localities. Many would happily do non-driving tasks.
- **University career offices** — students want flexible work.
- **Influencer micro-partnerships** — small Sri Lankan lifestyle influencers (10k–50k followers) doing real tasks on the platform. Authentic > polished.

What to avoid

- Don't blanket-launch the whole island on day one. You'll have empty marketplaces in 9 cities and a thin one in Colombo.
- Don't pay doers a “guarantee” to be online. PickMe doesn't, Uber stopped doing it. Pay for completed tasks only.
- Don't chase celebrities or big PR pre-product. Get the unit economics right in one suburb first.

10. Regulatory & legal homework

You're in Sri Lanka, and the gig economy here is loosely regulated, which is both opportunity and risk. Things to handle before launch:

1. **Register the business.** Private limited company through the Department of Registrar of Companies. You'll need this for a business bank account and for PayHere onboarding.
2. **Business bank account** with Sampath (PayHere's preferred partner) or Commercial Bank.
3. **Terms of Service and Privacy Policy.** Don't copy from TaskRabbit — get a Sri Lankan lawyer to draft them. Critical clauses: doer is independent contractor (not employee), platform liability disclaimer, dispute arbitration, data handling under PDPA (Personal Data Protection Act of Sri Lanka, in force).
4. **PDPA compliance.** Sri Lanka's Personal Data Protection Act applies. You need consent flows, data deletion on request, and a registered Data Protection Officer once you scale.
5. **PCI-DSS scope avoidance.** Use PayHere's hosted checkout — never store card data on your servers. This keeps you out of PCI-DSS Level 1 hell.
6. **Tax.** You're collecting money on behalf of doers and taking a fee. VAT and SVAT rules apply on your *fees*, not on the GMV passed through to doers. Get a chartered accountant to set up proper books from week one. The CBSL (Central Bank) does not currently regulate marketplaces, but if you ever hold escrow balances at scale, that may change — design your system so funds are held in a segregated trust account at your bank, not on your balance sheet.
7. **Insurance.** Talk to Ceylinco / SLIC / AIA about a public liability policy that covers third-party damage caused by doers during a task. This is what your "Trust Fund" backstops in early months.

11. Risks and how to mitigate them

Risk	Mitigation
PickMe launches an "errands" feature	Focus narrowly on tasks PickMe doesn't do well (multi-hour, judgment-required, in-home). Build deeper doer profiles than they need to. Win on trust + specialization.
Bad incident (fraud, theft, harassment)	Strict KYC, escrow, in-app chat records, insurance + Trust Fund, transparent communication when something goes wrong. Don't try to hide incidents — handle them publicly and well.

Risk	Mitigation
Female-doer safety	Optional gender filters on both sides, mandatory photo + live location during in-home tasks, partnership with a women’s safety NGO for advisory, faster SOS response in early cities.
Doer earnings race-to-bottom	Pricing hints, no race-bidding by default, minimum task floors (e.g., no task under Rs. 500), monthly bonuses for top-rated doers.
Off-platform leakage (poster + doer arrange directly next time)	Don’t reveal phone numbers, mask chat, make in-platform repeat-booking faster than off-platform (one-tap “rebook this doer”), loyalty rewards for repeat in-platform bookings.
Economic downturn / currency volatility	Price in LKR, settle daily, don’t hold large cash balances, keep ops costs low. The 2022 crisis didn’t kill PickMe — it actually grew because more people needed side income.
Solo-founder burnout	Don’t try to be CEO + CTO + ops + support indefinitely. By month 4, hire one ops person to handle KYC + disputes. By month 9, hire a junior engineer.

12. Naming considerations

Bad-pattern Sri Lankan startup names: anything ending in “-Lanka,” anything that’s a Sinhala/Tamil pun only locals get, anything that sounds like an existing brand.

Good-pattern: short, easy to type, works in all three languages, says what it does or evokes the feeling.

A few directions to brainstorm in: - **Action verbs:** Tap, Done, Ping, Fetch, Run - **Helper metaphors:** Hand, Helper, Buddy, Mate - **Speed metaphors:** Quick, Flash, Snap, Now - **Localized but accessible:** Karyaya (කාර්‍යයා = “the task”), Vaeda (වැඩ = “work”) — use sparingly; check Tamil equivalents

Examples: **Tappa**, **HandyLK**, **GetItDone**, **NearTask**, **DoneByYou**, **Helpa**. Don’t pick the name until you’ve checked: domain (.lk and .com), Face-

book handle, Instagram handle, App Store/Play Store availability, and that it's not a slang word in Sinhala or Tamil that means something embarrassing.

13. The honest summary

You have a real opportunity. The market is underserved, the infrastructure (payments, KYC, smartphones) is now mature enough in Sri Lanka, and you're personally capable of building it.

The hardest parts will not be the code. They will be: 1. Getting the first 50 doers to trust you enough to verify and stay active. 2. Handling the first nasty dispute well (you will get a "they damaged my car" claim within 6 months — how you handle it sets your reputation). 3. Resisting the temptation to launch in 5 cities at once. 4. Not under-pricing your service fee to chase volume.

Ship narrow, ship trusted, ship in Colombo, then scale. That's the recipe TaskRabbit, Airtasker, Urban Company, and PickMe all used. The ones that died (Taskbob, SBricks, Handy in many markets) all tried to do too much too fast.

Build the MVP. Run the closed beta. Then come back and we'll iterate based on what you actually learn from real Colombo users — that data will be more valuable than anything in this document.

Appendix A: Recommended next 30 days

1. Register a Sri Lankan private limited company.
2. Open a Sampath business current account (for PayHere).
3. Get a Sri Lankan IT lawyer to draft TOS/Privacy/PDPA framework (~Rs. 50,000–80,000 one-time).
4. Apply for PayHere merchant account. Test the sandbox.
5. Lock in a name and trademark it (NIPO — National Intellectual Property Office).
6. Build a clickable Figma prototype of the poster + doer flows. Show it to 20 people in your target neighborhood. Listen. Iterate.
7. Only then start writing production code.